

TENUOUS PEACE

◀ **REWIND**

CATCH THEM YOUNG:
Militants put guns in the
hands of children too

PRAMOD PUSHKARNA



With the Punjab Accord of 1985 in a shambles after the assassination of H.S. Longowal, the crisis in the state only deepened with a split in the Akalis that left Chief Minister S.S. Barnala increasingly isolated. The terrorist toll rose to 600 while Julio Ribeiro's bullet-for-bullet strategy was soon running out of ammunition. The violence, once restricted to the border areas of Amritsar and Gurdaspur, had spread to Hoshiarpur, Jalandhar, Ludhiana and Faridkot. Hundreds of terror-stricken Hindu families fled to neighbouring Haryana and Himachal Pradesh. On August 10, General A.S. Vaidya was shot dead by assassins of the Khalistan Commando Force while driving his car home from the market in Pune, where he was living after retirement. He died instantly of head and neck wounds. Vaidya was Chief of Staff when Indira Gandhi sent the army into the Golden Temple during Operation Blue Star. There was no going back for the insurgents because extremism in Punjab was a life-long trap.

FIRST CUT

The first full-blown AIDS cases in India were reported in six prostitutes in Chennai in May. While the appearance of the dreaded disease in India was

scary enough, what was most disconcerting was the fact that it had happened despite Tamil Nadu being the only state in the country with a full-fledged AIDS detection programme.

◀ **DID YOU KNOW**

Smita Patil, one of India's foremost arthouse actors, died on December 13 due to complications after the birth of her son. She was only 31 and had appeared in films like *Ardh Satya* and *Mirch Masala*.